

It is almost as if the controller went on a diet and has come out sleeker and more ergonomic than ever before. When the Sega Genesis first came out, its controller seemed to have been custom-made for your hands; the 360 controller gives you that same feeling.

The design of the 360 controller underwent a radical change, with Microsoft dumping the earlier six-button interface for a four-button one, akin to the DualShock. However, the buttons on the 360 controller are made of hard plastic in a bubble-like shape, thus giving a nice ‘clickety’ feel to the user.

MS did stick with one aspect of the original controller – using an analogue stick in the top-left corner for movement, and moving the navigation pad to where the left analogue stick lies on the DualShock. Honestly, this makes a world of a difference, as your thumbs are aligned while playing any game.

The controller still uses eight buttons, with the R1 and L1 buttons being relegated to small stubs, while the R2 and L2 buttons are long triggers. Whether it’s a coincidence that the SixAxis also went with a trigger-format or not is up for debate, but what is of importance is that the 360’s triggers feel a lot more comfortable to hold and pull.

In the wireless controller, the added weight of the dual AA batteries tends to throw the weight ratio off just a little bit, but it is never so inconvenient that you would strain any muscle. A set of high-alkaline batteries, such as Duracell or Energizer, will easily last you for about 20-25 hours of gameplay.

The Xbox 360 controller also has a new ‘Guide’ button in the centre of its face that provides a new functionality. This button is divided into four quadrants that light up to provide gamers with different types of information during game play. For instance, during a split-screen multiplayer match, a particular quadrant will light up to indicate to a player which part of the screen he or she is playing on at that time. The Guide button can also light up to let a player know he has received a message from another gamer. In this case, when the user pushes the button, he or she visits the Xbox dashboard, which provides access to features such as messaging friends, downloading content, voice chat and customising soundtracks, all while staying in the game. The Guide button also allows users to turn off the controller or the console by holding the Guide button longer.

Play & Charge Kit

Since the wireless 360 controller does not come with a built-in battery that can be recharged, Microsoft has introduced battery packs and rechargeable kits for it.

The battery pack for the Xbox 360 controller is made of two NiMH batteries that can provide up to 25 hours of continuous gaming.

This battery pack can be recharged using the ‘Play & Charge Kit’, wherein the wireless control has to be plugged into the Xbox 360’s USB port. While the control can be used during this process, it is advisable not to as it can cause damage to the device.